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PART I

Methodological and Doctrinal
Considerations for a Theology
of the Sacraments



ONE

The Sacraments as Theology

Wisdom and Theological Method

The purpose of this chapter is to map out a foundational approach to sacramental theology that is open to the breadth of wisdom that emerges from the teaching of Scripture and of the Fathers, Doctors, and Magisterium of the Church. As noted above, in many of its branches, schools, and accepted articulations, Christian theology today has lost its ties to its foundation in metaphysical and theological wisdom and, as a result, it stands cut off from its most profound dimensions. This is the case in sacramental theology, too.

The Pursuit of Wisdom and Sacramental Theology

Perhaps the single characteristic that most differentiates the *via moderna* from the view of the pre-Enlightenment Christians (and ancients) is the abandonment by modernity of the pursuit of wisdom as the aim of both profane and sacred learning. A significant factor to note in this drift away from the pursuit of wisdom, which has many cultural, political, and intellectual components, is that shortly after Aquinas's death in 1274/5 some authors began to construe the nature

of philosophical knowledge in a new way.¹ This new presentation of philosophical knowledge gave birth to an understanding of the nature and order of reality that called into question the status of many basic tenets of the Christian faith and metaphysical patrimony. Speaking of the challenges that these trends pose in the context of the sacramental liturgy of the Church, Joseph Ratzinger observed, “The whole problem of knowledge in the modern world is present. If an interior opening-up does not occur in man that enables him to see more than what can be measured and weighed, to perceive the reflection of divine glory in creation, then God remains excluded from our field of vision.”²

It is beyond the scope of this chapter and book to provide a detailed historical presentation of the problem of knowledge in the modern world; what follows is merely a sketch of broad themes that merit closer inspection in another format. The *via moderna* has at least three basic, interrelated tenets that pose particular challenges for sacramental theologians today.³ First, there is a new emphasis on the practical and productive forms of knowledge, which displace the contemplative and speculative dimensions of classical and Christian thought.⁴ Second, there is the reduction of reality to the empirical and spatial realm.⁵ Third, causality and knowledge of being through

1. For a helpful presentation of Aquinas’s teaching on wisdom in its many aspects, which has also sections on wisdom in pre-Aristotelian thought, in Aristotle, the Old and New Testaments, and St. Augustine, see Kieran Conley, *A Theology of Wisdom: A Study in St. Thomas* (Dubuque, Iowa: The Priory Press, 1963).

2. Joseph Cardinal Ratzinger, *The Spirit of the Liturgy*, trans. John Saward (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2000), 122.

3. For a helpful application of how some of these tenets affected Eucharistic theology after Aquinas, see Marilyn McCord Adams, *Some Later Medieval Theories of the Eucharist: Thomas Aquinas, Giles of Rome, Duns Scotus, and William of Ockham* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 4–28. For a discussion of Ockham’s (†1347) break with the prior reception of Aristotle’s categories, see Armand Maurer, *The Philosophy of William of Ockham in the Light of its Principles* (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 1999), 40.

4. In the “aphorisms” of his *The New Organon*, Bacon (†1626) famously declared that “Knowledge is power.” See Francis Bacon, *The New Organon and Related Writings* (Indianapolis, Ind.: The Bobbs-Merrill Company, Inc., 1960), 39 [aphorism III].

5. Descartes’s proclivity for mathematics gave him a decided preference for geometrical models of reality. “Most of all,” Descartes (†1650) explains in his “Discourse on

causes are reduced to the a priori categories of the mind, which are imposed on experience but not derived from it.⁶ These tenets progressively moved Western thought into a more practically focused, empirically and spatially circumscribed, and subjectively reliant mode of thought and view of the world.

The focus on production and the material order, and the rejection of a metaphysics of causation, make more difficult the necessary “interior opening-up” that Ratzinger describes. A reappropriation of the wisdom tradition can serve as an avenue for an intellectual and spiritual renewal in the face of these challenges. For Christians and the ancients, by contrast, the pursuit of wisdom corresponds to a whole way of life – a most fully human form of life.

The great schoolmen of the Middle Ages, especially Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274), loved quoting the ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle (ca. 350 B.C.), about the nature of wisdom. “Among other things” about what constitutes a wise man, Aquinas explains that Aristotle “includes the notion that ‘it belongs to the wise man to

Method,” “was I delighted with mathematics because of the certainty of its demonstrations and the evidence of its reasoning; but I did not yet understand its true use, and, believing that it was of service only in the mechanical arts, I was astonished that, seeing how firm and solid was its basis, no loftier edifice had been reared thereupon.” See *Discourse on the Method of Rightly Conducting the Reason and Seeking for Truth in the Sciences*, in *Descartes: Key Philosophical Writings*, trans. Elizabeth Haldane and G. R. T. Ross (Hertfordshire: Wordsworth Editions, 1997), 75 [Part I, §8]. For a helpful presentation of the movement to a quantitative and material understanding of reality from Ockham to Descartes, see Matthew R. McWhorter, “The Real Distinction of Substance and Quantity: John of St. Thomas in Contrast to Ockham and Descartes,” *The Modern Schoolman* 85 (2008): 225–45.

6. At the apex of the Enlightenment, Immanuel Kant’s (†1804) critique of the range of metaphysical knowledge asserted that the mind could not know things in themselves. The metaphysical study of being with recourse to causal knowledge derived from the observation of change in the material world gives way under Kant’s critique to the study of appearances (phenomena) as experienced in the mind of the knower. “Kant,” Avery Dulles explains, “made room for faith by redefining it, no longer as belief accepted on external authority, but rather as belief resting on motives that are subjectively sufficient and objectively insufficient.” See Avery Dulles, *The Assurance of Things Hoped For: A Theology of Christian Faith* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1994), 70. For a critical outline of Kant’s thought as it relates to Catholic theology, see Giovanni Sala, “What Use Is Kant for Theology?” in *Wisdom and Holiness, Science and Scholarship: Essays in Honor of Matthew L. Lamb*, ed. Michael Dauphinais and Matthew Levering (Ave Maria, Fla.: Sapientia Press, 2007), 293–314.

order.’”⁷ How is true wisdom related to ordering or governing? Aquinas explains that what guides the wise ordering of things is the end or purpose. “Since the end of each thing,” Aquinas explains, “is its good, a thing is then best disposed when it is fittingly ordered to its end.”⁸

What is the highest good or purpose of humanity; what is the ultimate thing for which it is created? Because man is a rational creature, his highest or ultimate good, Aquinas argues, is truth. Aquinas takes this argument to be more than a philosophical conclusion. Truth as humanity’s end corresponds to the very mission and purpose of Jesus Christ. “Divine Wisdom testifies,” Aquinas notes, “that He has assumed flesh and come into the world in order to make known the truth: ‘For this was I born, and for this I came into the world, that I should give testimony to the truth’ (John 18:37).”⁹

What does all of this have to do with a book on general sacramental theology? Our “technocratic” mindset (as Pope Francis terms it), which reduces knowledge to production and the nature of reality itself to the spatial-empirical order, makes it all the more difficult to appreciate the spiritual and supernatural significance of the sacraments. Spirituality is seen as another “technique” to master with appropriate reading or training, rather than the discovery and following of the ordering principle of human life. But by his mission, by his life, death, and Resurrection, Christ orders humanity to the truth itself, the truth of human existence, and the true way of living. In Christ, the goal to which humanity is to direct the entirety of life is brought to light and the source of grace to bring this motion to rest is found. “The counsels of a wise friend are of great use,” Aquinas explains, “according to Proverbs 27:9: ‘Ointment and perfumes rejoice the heart: and the good counsels of a friend rejoice the soul.’ But Christ is our wisest and greatest friend. Therefore His counsels are supremely use-

7. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa contra gentiles*, book I, 1, trans. Anton Pegis (Notre Dame, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 1955), 59. Aquinas is citing Aristotle’s *Metaphysics*, book I, 2 (982a18).

8. Aquinas, *Summa contra gentiles* (Pegis), 59.

9. Ibid, 60 [2].

ful and becoming.”¹⁰ The Christian life, then, is the pursuit of discipleship in the counsels of humanity’s “wisest and greatest friend,” Jesus Christ. In sacramental worship, likewise, humanity must seek the wise counsel of Christ’s word and teaching.

The sources of Christian theology do not reduce the practice of religion to the practical ends of making or technique, nor do they reduce the totality of knowledge to the realm of the senses; rather, the life of faith is unveiled as the ultimate pursuit of wisdom, a pursuit that recognizes life with God as the central ordering principle. A wisdom-based approach to faith (and life) is marked by the recognition that eternal life is not something that can be obtained, made, or produced by the mastery of some technique or self-help program; it is sought, rather, in a life ordered to friendship with God. The Psalmist (a profound representative of the wisdom tradition) declares quite clearly that the happy or “blessed” man is one whose “delight is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he meditates day and night” (Psalm 1:2). Viewed within the order of wisdom, the sacraments orient the faithful to the spiritual and supernatural goal of rational life that lies beyond the horizon of the empirical realm and the human power of production.

For this reason Aquinas considers theology or what he calls “sacred doctrine” to be the highest intellectual pursuit. “Sacred doctrine derives its principles,” Aquinas explains, “not from any human knowledge, but from the divine knowledge, through which, as through the highest wisdom, all our knowledge is set in order.”¹¹ The knowledge that is communicated in divine Revelation and received by faith “treats of God viewed as the highest cause,” and more importantly, “as far as He is known to Himself alone and revealed to others. Hence sacred doctrine is especially called wisdom.”¹²

10. *Summa theologiae* I-II, q. 108, a. 4, sed contra. Translations from the *Summa theologiae* are from *Summa theologiae*, Complete set, Latin-English (Lander, Wyo.: The Aquinas Institute, 2012), cited hereafter as *ST*. See also Romanus Cessario’s “The Sacramental Mediation of Divine Friendship and Communion,” in Romanus Cessario, *Theology and Sanctity* (Ave Maria, Fla.: Sapientia Press, 2014), 34–68.

11. *ST* I, q. 1, a. 6, ad 1.

12. *ST* I, q. 1, a. 6.

Ramifications of Wisdom-based Theology for the Sacraments

Sacred doctrine is distinguished from natural philosophy “because it proceeds from principles established by the light of a higher science [than reason alone], namely, the science of God and the blessed.”¹³ Aquinas’s articulation of the sapiential nature of theology and its unique method of proceeding by way of principles communicated or revealed by God has three important ramifications for a foundational sacramental theology.

First, as theology or sacred doctrine, sacramental theology (and liturgical studies) must have as its measure the knowledge bestowed by divine Revelation, the magisterial interpretation of Revelation by the Church, and the privileged witness of the saints and doctors. This does not mean that historical research into the Church’s liturgy or the celebration of a particular sacrament can be dismissed by the theologian. The work of theology requires, in addition to historical and philosophical standards embraced by the academy, accountability to the light of divine Revelation.

Second, and following upon the first point, because Christian theology draws upon the wisdom that is contained in divine Revelation and that thus grants access to the wisdom of God himself, arbitrary reasoning ought not to be posited as a form of authentic theological explanation. This means that there is more to the sacraments than merely an abstract divine command or the caprice of ecclesial authority. The sacraments are the product of divine authority, but this authority is ordered by God’s wisdom, which aims to lead us to friendship with himself. Ecclesial governance of the sacraments follows upon the order of wisdom that instituted the sacraments. As noted above, “the office” of the wise is to “order.” Christ’s fulfillment of the liturgical life of Israel by his priestly sacrifice and the continuation of this fulfillment in the sacraments of the New Law draws those who share in it into God’s all-wise plan of salvation.

13. *ST I*, q. 1, a. 2.

It is tempting to read the doctrine of worship through the lens of God's omnipotence without reference to his wisdom and goodness. "Why go to Church on Sunday — God is everywhere, right?" "Why go to confession — at all! — *let alone to a priest? God hears me when I ask for forgiveness, right?*" Such questions, while quite understandable, do not proceed from a docility to the promptings of God's wisdom. The real question for all Christians ought to be, not what, hypothetically, the omnipotent God can do, but rather, what is the actual path that he calls his disciples to follow? Catholics have long recognized that God's power is not constricted by the sacraments. But, a truly wisdom-based approach to theology looks to the knowledge of faith to learn the meaning of each sacramental sign and the place of the sacraments within the divinely ordered life of the Church. God does not thus command sacramental worship simply for the sake exacting obedience from the faithful. Rather, the sacramental system provides acts of worship that relate the faithful to God within a just and orderly pattern of fulfillment that unfolds according to the divine wisdom.

There is a culture that is intrinsic to the unfolding of the divine wisdom with regard to the material elements and verbal formulae used in the sacraments. Bread, for example, is not merely a fare of Mediterranean and Near Eastern origin without any signification beyond its culinary usage. Bread was used in the very first Passover meal by the divine initiative on the night in which the Jews were freed from slavery by God (see Exodus 12:8); bread and wine were the sacrificial offerings of Melchizedek the high priest of Salem (see Genesis 14:8); bread was the divinely provided means of sustenance for the chosen people as they journeyed through the desert (see Exodus 16:4); fresh bread was placed before God each week on the Sabbath (see Exodus 25:30 and Leviticus 24:8); and Christ used bread to feed the multitudes and pique their interest in his identity (see John 6:5ff). The same could be said about the water of the flood, the Red Sea, or the Jordan River. As a result, the bread of the sacrament of the Eucharist and the water of Baptism are not merely expressions of the Church's historico-cultural origins, nor are they merely the

preferences of the worshipping community: when used within the Church, the bread and water are signs whose focal meaning is derived from their divine appropriation in the Old Law and by Christ.

The third ramification of the sapiential approach to the sacraments is an extension of the previous point. The sacraments are not products of people's religious longings or paternalistic projections. They are expressive, to be sure, of the faith of the worshipping members of the Church, but the faith expressed in the sacraments flows from the revelation of the divine wisdom and the founding intention of Christ himself as the author of what Aquinas calls the whole "rite of the Christian life."¹⁴ Describing Aquinas's approach to the liturgy and the sacraments, Liam Walsh makes the following helpful observation:

When he comes to deal with the core of the Church's liturgy, in his discussion of the sacraments towards the end of the *Tertia Pars*, he is not opening up a new tract but simply coming in his own good time to discuss the actual working out of the relationship between God and his creation that has been the subject of his single-minded study from the first questions of the *Prima Pars*. Throughout the *Summa* he is writing theology pure and simple, not the theology of this or that. He does not present a theology of the liturgy but incorporates liturgy in his theology.¹⁵

The correspondence of (God-centered) theological knowledge rooted in faith with the divine wisdom provides an integrated view of reality that is not possible if a lower, less encompassing object, such as human experience or empirical knowledge, is posited as the starting point. "He who considers absolutely the highest cause of the whole universe," Aquinas argues,

namely God, is most of all called wise. Hence wisdom is said to be the knowledge of divine things, as Augustine says (*De Trin.* xii, 14). But sacred doctrine essentially treats of God viewed as the highest cause — not only so

14. In *ST* III, q. 63, a. 1. Thomas speaks of sacraments as ordered to "the perfecting of the soul in things pertaining to the Divine worship according to the rite of the Christian life [*secundum ritum Christianae vitae*]."

15. Liam Walsh, "Liturgy in the Theology of St. Thomas," *The Thomist* 38 (1974): 557–83, at 559.

far as He can be known through creatures just as philosophers knew Him — “That which is known of God is manifest in them” (Romans 1:19) — but also as far as He is known to Himself alone and revealed to others. Hence sacred doctrine is especially called wisdom.¹⁶

When Western philosophers, as briefly noted above, began to construe philosophical knowledge in a more empirically based manner, it became increasingly difficult for theologians to articulate the spiritual and causal aspects of faith meaningfully.¹⁷ Catherine Pickstock explains this difficulty as follows: “[B]y the breakdown of the traditional religious order, space becomes a pseudo-eternity which, unlike genuine eternity, is fully comprehensive to the human gaze, and yet supposedly secure from the ravages of time.”¹⁸ This breakdown culminates in what Pickstock names the “spatial illusion” of

16. STI, q. 1, a. 6.

17. One notable attempt to articulate the Church’s sacramental doctrine in terms that are more compatible with post-Kantian thought is the theology and ontology of symbol developed by Karl Rahner, SJ (†1984). Rahner’s thought was influenced by the engagement with Kant in the early transcendental Thomist Joseph Maréchal and in the philosophy of Martin Heidegger; the work of Kant and the work of Heidegger were both prominent during the years of Rahner’s seminary and academic formation. He attended the lectures of the Heidegger in 1934. Rahner advocated rooting the meaning of being in the symbolism of an agent’s actions: “all beings are by their nature symbolic, because they necessarily ‘express’ themselves in order to attain their own nature.” Karl Rahner, “The Theology of the Symbol,” in *More Recent Writings*, vol. 4 of *Theological Investigations*, trans. Kevin Smith (London: Darton, Longman, and Todd, 1966), 221–52, 224. When applied to the sacraments, this experiential and symbolic understanding of being turns the focus from God’s use of the liturgical signs to the symbolic expression of the being of the worshipping community in and through the rites of worship. For Rahner’s application of his doctrine of being to the sacraments, see his “Introduction” in Karl Rahner, *Meditations on the Sacraments* (New York: Seabury Press, 1977). For a helpful presentation of Rahner’s doctrine of symbol, see Patrick Burke, *Reinterpreting Rahner: A Critical Study of His Major Themes* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2002), passim. For an assessment of Rahner’s thought by one of his theological contemporaries, see William A. Van Roo, SJ, “Reflections on Karl Rahner’s ‘Kirche und Sakramente,’” *Gregorianum* 44 (1963): 465–500. For a summary and explanation of Rahner’s principal ideas and works, see Fergus Kerr, *Twentieth-Century Catholic Theologians: From Neoscholasticism to Nuptial Mysticism* (Oxford: Blackwell Publishing, 2007), 87–104. See also Conor Sweeney, *Sacramental Presence after Heidegger: Ontotheology, Sacraments, and a Mother’s Smile* (Cascade Books: Eugene, Ore., 2015).

18. Catherine Pickstock, *After Writing: On the Liturgical Consummation of Philosophy* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), 48.

modern and post-modern life, which creates a special challenge for the sacramental and liturgical order. “The illusions which [the spatial illusion] can encourage,” Pickstock observes, “are only *legitimized* by an increasing denial of genuine transcendence, understood as doxological reliance upon a donating source which one cannot command. Without eternity, space must be made absolute and the uncertainty of time’s source and end be suppressed.”¹⁹ This means that elements within the created order, such as experience of the physical world, displace the proper emphasis on the transcendent presence of God within the liturgy.

Aquinas’s stress on the importance of wisdom provides his sacramental theology with the tools to remain open to the divine transcendence and, by that openness, to avoid circumscribing the sacramental order within the spatial-empirical and experiential realms. One might legitimately ask if the teaching of divine Revelation calls for this broader, wisdom-based metaphysical view of the world. Attunement to wisdom, however, is what opens and orders humanity to a transcendent field of vision. Following John Paul II’s encyclical letter *Fides et Ratio*, Matthew Levering notes:

If dogmatic theology is not informed by metaphysical speculation, it cannot articulate the meaning of Scripture, because the mysteries revealed in Scripture are salvific truths intended for all human beings. Scripture’s meaning cannot be conveyed solely by more stories in addition to the stories of Scripture. Rather, the narrative of Scripture requires from the theologian the metaphysical questioning that investigates the revealed mysteries by seeking their “ontological, causal and communicative structures” [*Fides et ratio*, no. 66] and thus enables the theologian to express judgments about the meaning of Scripture’s claims about God and human beings.²⁰

Biblical Revelation, in short, makes claims that presuppose a metaphysical order without offering an explicit and full-blown philosophical treatment of that order — and the biblical theology of the

19. *Ibid.*, 49.

20. Matthew Levering, *Scripture and Metaphysics: Aquinas and the Renewal of Trinitarian Theology* (Oxford: Blackwell Publishing, 2004), 21.

sacraments is no exception. Questions about the relation of the sacraments to God's causal agency, the status of sacramental grace within the created order, the seating of sacramental character in the soul, all invite a wider, wisdom-based investigation into the sacramental life of the Church. As a result, the pursuit of wisdom by means of recourse to metaphysical contemplation within theological reflection issues from an invitation that is embedded within biblical Revelation itself.

John Henry Newman once asked:

What is the nearest approach in the way of symbols, in this world of sight and sense, to represent to us the glories of that higher world which is beyond our bodily perceptions? What are the truest tokens and promises here, poor though they may be, of what one day we hope to see hereafter, as being beautiful and rare?²¹

The pursuit of an answer to these two well-crafted questions opens the way for a consideration of the foundational principles of Catholic sacramental theology. The seven sacraments are, indeed, the visible tokens of God's action (the higher world) and presence to people, in the world, through the Church. The revealed and magisterial patrimony concerning the sacraments contains positive affirmations and implicit philosophical presuppositions that are simply not compatible with every modern and post-modern intellectual and philosophical project. This work views the challenges facing sacramental theology and spirituality today, in the words of Thomas Joseph White, OP, as an "opportunity to rediscover the true insights of Aquinas"²² and the ecclesial doctrine of general sacramental theology.

21. From May 31 of Newman's "Meditations on the Litany of Loretto for the Month of May," in John Henry Newman, *Selected Sermons, Prayers, and Devotions*, ed. John F. Thornton and Susan B. Varenne (New York: Vintage Spiritual Classics, 1999), 334.

22. White, *Wisdom in the Face of Modernity: A Study in Thomistic Natural Theology* (Ave Maria, Fla.: Sapientia Press, 2009), 27.